The National Games were last organised way back in 2015. In that year, swimmers Sajan Prakash and Aakanksha Vora had picked up the best male and female athlete award, respectively. Prakash was unstoppable in the pool with a haul of six gold and three silver medals, while Vora landed five gold and a silver. Over the next few years, Prakash went on to represent India at two Olympic Games, while Vora turned out for the Harvard University swimming team and is now pursuing a corporate career in the US. Clearly, a lot can happen over seven years.

Though there has always been a cloud of uncertainty hovering over the National Games in the recent past, this 36th edition finally unfolded seamlessly in Gujarat. A few big names such as Olympians Neeraj Chopra and Bajrang Punia chose to opt out, but for those who showed up, it all just seemed like another day at the office. While the likes of Mirabai Chanu, Bhavani Devi and Elavenil Valarivan clinched gold medals with relative ease, a few other key contests and new records made the event a gripping watch. The Games also presented the perfect platform for fresh faces to make their mark and old warhorses to stage a comeback.

Shail Desai



HARMEET DESAI, *Table Tennis*

FOR A FEW YEARS now, Harmeet Desai has operated in the shadow of G. Sathiyan, who came into the event as the top seed. The two faced off in the semi-final of the men's singles, where Desai made the home advantage count, beating him 4-2 en route to the gold. He also combined with Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah to pick up the team gold for Gujarat.





ROSY MEENA PAULRAJ, *Pole Vault*

A PROMISING gymnast in her previous avatar, the athlete from Tamil Nadu took to pole vaulting just three years ago. Paulraj's diminutive stature raised a few eyebrows, but she made her mark with gold (4.00m) at the Federation Games in April. For those still in doubt, she sprang a surprise this time around. She not only took the top spot after clearing 4.20m, but also smashed V. Surekha's national record (4.15m) from 2014.







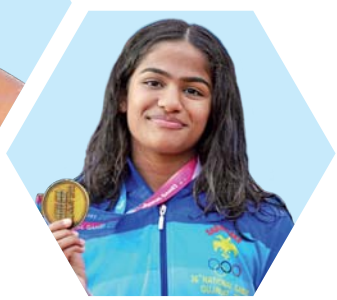


RAM BABOO, *Race Walk*

A FEW YEARS AGO, an injury brought Baboo's running career to a grinding halt. It was only then that he took up race walking. Though short on experience, he made his abilities count as he took gold in the 35km category (2.36.34) of the Games. In the process, he relegated former national record holder, Juned Khan of Haryana, to second place.

SRIHARI NATARAJ, *Swimming*

DESPITE SOME promising talent in the pool, the contest among men was always going to be between Olympians Sajan Prakash of Kerala and his younger counterpart, Karnataka's Srihari Nataraj. By the penultimate day, both had five medals, but in the 100m freestyle, one of the last events, Nataraj trumped Prakash to register a new meet record and finished with a tally of six gold, a silver and a bronze.



HASHIKA RAMACHANDRA, *Swimming*

AT JUST 14 YEARS, Hashika Ramachandra picked up a staggering haul—six golds, a silver and a bronze—rewriting three individual meet records along the way.